



Steady Under Pressure, But Softer Than Needed

Giving Difficult Feedback | Manager | Speaking to: Junior to me | Resistant tone | 2 October 2026

OVERALL PERFORMANCE

You held the conversation with composure and showed genuine accountability when the pushback landed, which is a real strength at manager level. However, your opening moves were reactive rather than leading, and you spent more energy responding to James than shaping the conversation yourself. At manager level, you are expected to set the tone, name the standard clearly, and guide the exchange toward a resolution, not wait for the other person to arrive there.

COMMUNICATION INTELLIGENCE SCORES

0–40 needs work • 41–70 developing • 71–100 strong

Assertiveness

72

Influence

55

Clarity

68

Listening

65

Emotional Regulation

80

Empathy and Connection

60

COMMUNICATION STYLE

Measured but Reactive

Your measured tone kept the conversation professional and prevented escalation, which matters with a resistant junior colleague. The reactive quality meant you were often responding to James's framing rather than establishing your own, which slightly reversed the power dynamic.

WHAT YOU DID WELL

- You acknowledged James's workload concern before pushing back on it, which kept him in the conversation rather than shutting him down.
- When James challenged the framing that the team had to find the errors, you stayed composed rather than doubling down, which was the right call in the moment.
- You responded to James's self-awareness at the end by opening the door to a practical solution, which moved the conversation toward resolution rather than leaving it in the problem.

PRIMARY DEVELOPMENT AREA

Your weakest area was the opening: you stated the procedural concern without anchoring it clearly to impact or to a shared standard, which left James room to chip away at the framing almost immediately. At manager level, the expectation is that you open a difficult conversation with enough clarity that the other person understands exactly what the issue is, why it matters, and what needs to change, before they have a chance to reframe it. The gap here is between naming a general concern and making a specific, grounded case that is hard to redirect. Next time, lead with the concrete observable facts, name the actual impact on the team, and state the standard you need met, all before you invite their perspective.

HUMAN NEEDS IN THE SCENE

The needs most at stake for you and the other person in this conversation, not targets to meet but signals about what was driving the dynamic.

YOUR NEEDS

Certainty	Variety	Significance	Connection	Growth	Contribution
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THE OTHER PERSON'S NEEDS

Certainty	Variety	Significance	Connection	Growth	Contribution
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Your core needs in this conversation were certainty around process compliance and confidence that your team's output meets the required standard, as well as a sense of contribution to the client relationship your team is responsible for. James's needs were most visibly around significance, wanting his context and effort to be seen rather than reduced to a procedural failure, and connection, specifically a sense that you were engaging with him as a person rather than delivering a verdict. Your communication did acknowledge James's workload concern, which partially met his significance need, but it did not explicitly name that you could see the pressure he was under before making the ask. That small move, naming his likely experience before stating the problem, would have made your message land with less resistance and more genuine receptiveness.

TAKE THIS INTO THE REAL CONVERSATION

When someone pushes back on the facts, the most powerful thing you can do is hold the facts calmly and make the impact impossible to argue with.

NEXT TIME IN THE LAB

Practise opening a difficult feedback conversation by leading with three specific observable facts, naming the concrete impact on the team or client, and only then inviting the other person's perspective. This sequence builds the credibility and control a manager needs before the other person has a chance to reframe the issue.

A STRONGER VERSION OF THAT MOMENT

This relates to your opening statement, where you named the procedural concern but did not yet anchor it to specific impact or invite James's perspective before he took the lead. You could have said: 'James, I want to talk through something specific with you: in each of the last three weekly reports, the figures didn't match the source data, and we had to correct them before client submission, which delayed the team on each occasion. I know you've been carrying a lot and I want to understand what's been getting in the way, because the standard we need is that figures are checked against source before they go out, and I want to help you get there consistently.'

REGISTER NOTE

Your language was professional and appropriate, but slightly too tentative for a manager addressing a junior direct report on a repeated performance issue, leaning toward peer-level dialogue rather than clear managerial direction.